

film reviews

Blast from the Past

MEHBOOBA

Director: Afzal Khan
Starring: Sanjay Dutt, Ajay Devgan, Manisha Koirala

Now why would anyone watch *Mehbooba*, a movie that was seven years in the making? One, it shows us how far Hindi movies have travelled in this short span—the heroine sleeps with a man before marriage and it becomes a *kala daag* she has to bear all her life. Two, there is a certain charm in watching a winsome Manisha Koirala. Three, Sanjay Dutt looks great wearing sunglasses even at night. And four, and this is important in these days of inflation, there is a certain pleasure in having an air-conditioned hall all to yourself given the steep price of movie tickets. Clearly viewers are not fools. The



THAT LOVING FEELING: Koirala and Devgan get cosy

outdated theme of the film (two brothers are unknowingly in love with the same woman and one of them will die in a great act of sacrifice), the number of bottles of Johnny Walker consumed (sophisticated folk in Hindi cinema now drink French wine) and the use of satellite phones (clearly this film predates cellphones) marks it as a dead duck. The hero wears a black singlet and

the heroine a red chiffon sari and both dance in the rain—in Bollywood circa 2008 they would just hit the bed. While I would hesitate to call it a classic in the manner of that awful *Clerk*, it's got a good shot, along with *Love Story 2050*, of being in the list of the year's worst films. My favourite scene? Dutt and Ajay Devgan in the jacuzzi together. **Ew.**

by Kaveree Bamzai

History Unspooled

INQILAB

Director: Gauhar Raza
Narrated by: Zohra Segal

Inqilab is a class apart from the spate of Bollywood films, which celebrate the legend of Bhagat Singh. It's not a biographical account of his political persona, freedom struggle or even his embracing socialism. Beyond the guns and bombings, this 40-minute documentary unfolds Bhagat Singh, the person. It focuses on the little stories of the man who loved oranges and rasgullas, fought with his father on getting married



Bhagat Singh

and buried his nose deep in the pages of Lenin's book, minutes before he was hanged to death in Lahore Central Jail.

The drama comes from it being well-researched with a powerful narrative by actor Zohra Segal along

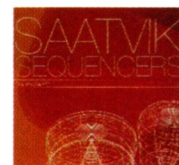
with scholars like Bipan Chandra, V.P. Dutt, K.N. Panikkar, Jagmohan Singh, Urvashi Butalia, Irfan Habib and Kamla Bhasin. Through documents and footage shot in Lahore, Amritsar, Kanpur, Delhi and Kolkata, it spans the life of an enigmatic freedom fighter.

Produced by the Nehru Memorial Museum and Library in collaboration with Act Now for Harmony and Democracy, the film marks the 100th birth anniversary of Bhagat Singh and celebrates 60 years of India's independence. Available on DVD in Hindi. Price: Rs 50.

by Deepika Khatri

music reviews

The Right Keys



Audioashram
Rs 500

THE MIDDLE PATH
Saatvik Sequencers
is a conceptual music project by

Nikhel Kumar Mahajan and Hari Singh. Both the artistes have a vivid background in electronic music. Each of the three 18-minute compositions is built on a solid framework of intricate Indian classical music ragas with electronic drifts that induce dreamy nonchalance. The ragas keep to the basic times of the day—Ahir Bharaiv (morning), Bhimpalasi (afternoon) and Durga (evening). The musicians who have collaborated the album are Ajay Prasanna (flute), Mukesh Sharma (sardar) and Bholenath Mishra (vocal). Enjoy the electro-classical sound. It's truly euphonic.



NA Classical
Rs 295

POSITIVE MUSIC
This album boasts of music that will induce calmness to the soul. Composed by santoor maestro Tarun

Bhattacharya, the four cds are excellent for soothing one's nerves after a stressful day. He has played ragas Hansdhwani, Bhoop, Gunkali accompanied by the keyboard, drums and violin. Bhattacharya has made innovations in the santoor, which produces a unique melody and is rich in tonality. His music has the ability to clear foul moods and lift depressed spirits.

by S. Sahaya Ranjit